SECOND WATCH: TABLETOP RULES

Tabletop rules for ships built in Drydock. Playtest edition, November 2026.

HOW TO USE THESE RULES

Every space epic follows the legendary crews. These rules are about everyone else: the thousands of ships doing the galaxy's work in the background while history happens on screen. **Each player is a captain** with a ship they built in Drydock. **The Fleet Commander** (the game's organizer) issues orders, sets the scene and decides what the big events mean for the fleet. The crew below decks are capable professionals at their posts, not individual characters.

There are two modes. **Skirmish** is ship-to-ship combat on a table with miniatures. **Adventure** is mission play, where the ship's design decides what its crew can attempt and the captain decides what they will try.

What you need:

- One record sheet per ship (Drydock → Launch → Second Watch), and a pencil to mark damage
- Six-sided dice: at least three per player (2d6 is the core roll)
- For Skirmish: a 3 × 3 ft table, a ruler in inches, and miniatures or tokens (the 50 mm print is sized for this)
- For Adventure: one person as the Fleet Commander, and one to five captains. Solo play uses the mission tables in place of a Fleet Commander.

Both modes read the same numbers off the same sheet. A ship that is great in a fight but weak in science will feel exactly that way on a survey mission.

Campaign profiles. Before the first session, the Fleet Commander picks one profile. They share the core roll, the record sheet and the missions; they differ in who the players are.

PROFILE	FEELS LIKE	PLAYERS ARE	CREW
Fleet	The background ships of a big fleet	Captains, one ship each, as a task force	A ship stat (Green, Seasoned, Veteran)
Bridge	One ship's senior staff	One captain plus department heads, sharing one ship	A ship stat; department heads lead it
Frontier	Small-crew sci-fi, Firefly-scale	The whole named crew of one small ship	Every crew member is a character
Armada	Last-fleet survival	Captains of a fleet that cannot replace losses	A ship stat; fuel, food and people are scarce

Any profile works in any setting. Fleet and Bridge suit a navy; Frontier suits a small crew scraping by; Armada suits a fleet on the run.

Group size. The sweet spot is one Fleet Commander and 2–3 players. Four or five still works if scenes split up. At six or more, run two task forces or add a second Fleet Commander as squadron commander. In Skirmish, add one enemy ship per two player ships.

CORE MECHANIC

Every uncertain action is one roll: **2d6 + department rating + crew quality + command bonus, meet or beat the target number.** Department ratings run from −2 to +4 and come off the record sheet. Crew quality is +0 to +2. The command bonus is +1 when the department is one of the captain's command style strengths.

TARGET	DIFFICULTY	EXAMPLE
6	Routine	Scan a planet with working sensors
8	Standard	Hit a ship at medium range
10	Hard	Beam out an away team through an ion storm
12	Heroic	Restart a reactor core that has lost containment

- **Advantage:** roll 3d6, keep the best two. You get it when the ship has a facility that fits the job (a survey lab for a star survey, a battle bridge when the main bridge is down).
- **Disadvantage:** roll 3d6, keep the worst two. You get it when a required system is missing or damaged. Advantage and disadvantage cancel out.

- **Pushing:** after a failed roll, the captain can push by marking 1 Stress on the ship (in a fight) or spending 1 Resolve (anywhere) to reroll.

Four results. Compare the total with the target. Nobody rolls twice to find out how well it went.

TOTAL	RESULT	WHAT HAPPENS
Beat the target by 3 or more	**Success, plus**	It works, and the table gains 1 Momentum
Meet or beat by 1–2	**Success**	It works
Miss by 1–2	**Success at a cost**	It works, but the Fleet Commander picks one cost: a system takes a hit, it takes longer (a clock ticks), someone is hurt, or it draws attention
Miss by 3 or more	**Fail forward**	It doesn't work, and the situation changes: the story moves on, worse

A double six always counts as Success, plus. A double one always fails forward and gives the Fleet Commander 1 Threat. In a Skirmish, attack rolls only hit or miss, to keep the fight fast; doubles still count.

Momentum and Threat. Two pools of tokens (dice or coins in the middle of the table) keep good and bad luck rolling forward.

- **Momentum** belongs to all the players, up to 6. Spend 1 for +1 on any roll (the +4 cap still applies), or 2 for advantage, an extra action in a scene, or one useful fact from the Fleet Commander.
- **Threat** belongs to the Fleet Commander. It starts each mission at one per captain, and grows with every double one, every push, and every trait compel the captain refuses. The Fleet Commander spends it on trouble: 1 to tick a danger clock, 2 for a new complication or reinforcements, 3 to make a roll Heroic that would have been Hard.
- Unspent Momentum fades at the end of a scene, one token per scene. Threat carries through the mission.

Ship traits. The record sheet lists up to five traits that Drydock reads from the design: *Families aboard, Saucer separation, Arrowhead hull, Three shuttlebays, Long conduit runs, Overstressed frame* and others. Change the ship and its traits change.

- **Invoke** a trait when it fits the moment and roll with advantage. "Three shuttlebays: we launch the evacuation in parallel."
- **Compel:** once per mission per trait, the Fleet Commander turns a trait into trouble. "Long conduit runs: the relay to engineering blows." The captain accepts and gains 1 Resolve, or refuses and the Fleet Commander gains 2 Threat.

- Flaws are marked on the sheet. They can still be invoked, but they are the Fleet Commander's favorites to compel.

The bonus cap. However many bonuses stack up, the total added to a roll is never more than **+4**. Without the cap, a Veteran crew in its best department would beat a Hard target on any roll. With it, even the best-fit ship still fails a Heroic task more often than not.

Why 2d6. Two dice make a bell curve: 7 is common and 2 or 12 are rare. Each +1 is worth more near the middle, so the ship's design matters more than luck; results are predictable enough to plan around; and doubles give critical successes and complications without a separate roll. All you need are ordinary six-sided dice.

BONUS	BEAT 6	BEAT 8	BEAT 10	BEAT 12
+0	72%	42%	17%	3%
+2	92%	72%	42%	17%
+4	97% (a double one always fails)	92%	72%	42%

THE SHIP RECORD SHEET

Every number on the sheet is calculated by Drydock from the design, so changing the ship in the app changes how it plays. The Explorer template is the worked example.

STAT	WHAT IT DOES	HOW THE APP DERIVES IT	EXPLORER
Size class	Sets turning and system boxes	S under 150 m, M 150–349 m, L 350–599 m, XL 600 m+	L
Hull	Damage boxes before the ship is lost	Cube root of mass in tonnes ÷ 6, minimum 6	29
Shields	Points per facing (fore, aft, port, starboard)	Square root of shield output in TW ÷ 2	9 each
Power	Points to spend each turn	Core output in TW ÷ 40	15
Speed	Inches moved per turn at full thrust	8 − 2 × log10(mass ÷ 100,000) + engine blocks, 2 to 10	6
Stress	Overload boxes; full means a breakdown	12 − structural stress % ÷ 10, minimum 3	8
Morale	Crew boxes for Adventure	Morale rating ÷ 20, 1 to 5	4
Supplies	Mission endurance	6, or endurance months ÷ 3 on Generic ships	6

Weapons. Each weapon line has attacks, damage, range and firing arc:

WEAPON	ATTACKS	DAMAGE	RANGE	ARC
Beam battery (one per 3 beam weapons or beams)	1	2	18"	All-round for arrays; forward 180° for banks and cannons
Torpedo launcher	1 per launcher	4	24"	Forward 90° or aft 90°, matching the torpedo rooms the engineer placed
Spinal gun (Generic)	1	8	30"	Forward 30°
Mass driver (Generic)	1 per 3 turrets	3	24"	All-round

Departments are the ratings the crew rolls with (−2 to +4):

DEPARTMENT	SOURCE IN THE DESIGN
Command	+1 base, +1 battle bridge, +1 auxiliary control
Helm	+2 at speed 8+, +1 at speed 6–7, −1 at speed 3 or less
Tactical	Tactical rating compared to hull size, +1 armory
Science	Science rating ÷ 120, up to +4
Engineering	+1 base, +1 damage control, +1 fabrication shops, +1 if power margin is over 20%
Medical	+1 ICU, +1 isolation ward, +1 medical hologram, −1 if casualty response is over 60 s
Operations	Transporters and small craft
Diplomacy	+1 diplomatic suites, +1 the lounge or lounge, +1 Explorer role, −1 Escort role

Systems track. Nine systems each get 2 boxes (S and M), 3 (L) or 4 (XL): Bridge, Engineering, Weapons, Shields, Sensors, Life support, Transporters, Small craft, Sickbay. A system with every box marked is offline; rolls that need it take disadvantage or fail outright.

SKIRMISH RULES

A skirmish is played in rounds of five phases. Most fights between two ships take 6–10 rounds and about 45 minutes.

1. **Power.** Each ship secretly splits its Power points between Engines, Weapons, Shields and Repairs, then reveals. Every 2 points in Engines buys 1" of movement, up to Speed. Each weapon fired costs 1 point (spinal guns cost 3). Each point in Shields restores 1 shield point to any facing. Each point in Repairs adds +1 to damage control.
2. **Movement.** Ships move in Helm order, lowest first, so the best pilot reacts last. Move straight ahead in inches. Turns are 45° and are made between inches: S ships may turn after every inch, M after every 2", L after every 3", XL after every 4".
3. **Fire.** Ships fire in Helm order, highest first. Pick a target in the weapon's arc and range, then roll 2d6 + Tactical: 7+ at short range (up to a third of the weapon's range), 8+ at medium, 10+ at long. Firing more than one weapon at the same target in a round gives the second and later shots +1.
4. **Damage.** Each hit removes shield points from the facing it struck, then marks Hull boxes with what is left. Torpedoes ignore 1 shield point. Every time a hit marks 3 or more Hull boxes, or on a natural 12, roll on the critical table.
5. **Damage control.** Each ship rolls 2d6 + Engineering + Repairs points, target 9. On a success, clear one box on the systems track. Then check Stress.

Critical hits (roll 2d6):

ROLL	SYSTEM HIT	EFFECT WHILE DAMAGED
2	Engineering	Lose 3 Power each round; if the track fills, reactor breach in 1d6 rounds
3–4	Life support	Mark 1 Morale each round
5	Transporters	No boarding, no evacuation
6	Sensors	Tactical rolls at long range fail
7	Weapons	One weapon line cannot fire
8	Shields	One facing drops to 0
9	Small craft	No launch or recovery
10–11	Sickbay	Crew losses double after the fight
12	Bridge	Disadvantage on Helm and Tactical until repaired, unless a battle bridge or auxiliary control is fitted

Stress and overload. Spending more than the ship's Power in a round is allowed: each point over marks 1 Stress box. When the Stress track fills, the spaceframe buckles: mark 1d6 Hull boxes and roll a critical. This is how an overgunned escort plays: devastating for a few rounds, fragile if it keeps pushing.

Separation. Ships built with Two-section or Multi-vector separation may split during the Power phase. Each section gets its own sheet line using the app's section table: Hull, weapons and shields divide by section share, and sections without nacelles have Speed 3 and no FTL.

Victory. A ship is out when its Hull track fills, its crew surrenders (Morale track empty), or it leaves the table. Scenarios can set other goals, such as escorting a freighter across the table or holding a point for 5 rounds.

Abandon ship. When the Hull track fills, the captain can order abandon ship instead of going down with it, and must if the reactor core is breaching. Everything then depends on the lifeboats listed on the record sheet:

- **Lifeboats fitted:** the crew escapes. The ship is lost, but the captain keeps Renown and traits, and the crew keeps its quality tier when it moves to a new ship. The lifeboats are now drifting and need rescuing, which makes a ready-made next mission.
- **No lifeboats:** only those who reach shuttles and transporters in time survive. The captain survives, but the crew drops one quality tier.
- **Armada play:** a ship abandoned with lifeboats costs half its Survivors boxes, rounded up; without them, all of them.

Lifeboats seat four, or six when crowded. Drydock fits enough for everyone aboard plus a 10% margin, shows them as hatches on the hull and as lifeboat stations on the deck plan, and prints the count on the record sheet.

ADVENTURE RULES

In Adventure, each player is the captain of their own ship. A mission runs as **Orders → Transit → 3 to 5 Scenes → Resolution → Debrief**, about 90 minutes. The Fleet Commander delivers the orders and runs the debrief, in character if the table enjoys it.

Captains. The captain is the only character a player keeps. In each scene the captain gives the order (who acts, how, and at what risk) and the player rolls for that department. The crew carry it out. A good captain's skill is in choosing which department to send, and when to spend Resolve.

Command style. Each captain picks one style. It gives +1 (the command bonus) to its two departments and one ability usable once per mission.

STYLE	COMMAND BONUS	ONCE PER MISSION
Explorer	Science, Diplomacy	Turn a failed Survey or First contact roll into a partial success with a clue
Tactician	Tactical, Helm	Before a Skirmish, place your ship anywhere in your deployment zone after seeing the enemy
Diplomat	Diplomacy, Command	Make a hostile party pause for one scene to talk
Engineer	Engineering, Operations	Bring one offline system back with 1 box clear
Healer	Medical, Command	Recover 2 Morale boxes
Maverick	Helm, Command	Turn disadvantage into advantage on one roll

Resolve. A captain starts each mission with 3 Resolve. Spend 1 to reroll any failed roll, or to add +1 after seeing the dice. Resolve does not carry over.

Renown and Command traits. At each debrief, the Fleet Commander awards 1 Renown for a completed mission, plus 1 for a hard choice made well or a big event handled with credit. Every 3 Renown buys one Command trait (up to 5):

- **Steady hand:** once per scene, ignore a complication.
- **Inspiring:** Morale cannot drop below 1 while you are aboard.
- **Old hand:** +1 Resolve per mission.

- **Fleet contacts:** once per mission, call in one favor from another ship or starbase.
- **Specialist:** pick a third department for your command bonus.
- **Reputation precedes you:** advantage on the first Diplomacy or Command roll against anyone who has heard of you.

Crew quality. The crew is the ship's own stat, not a set of characters. Every roll on that ship adds its crew quality:

TIER	BONUS	HOW IT CHANGES
Green	+0	New ships and new crews start here (the Fleet Commander may start a Capital-level or higher campaign at Seasoned)
Seasoned	+1	After 3 completed missions
Veteran	+2	After 6 more completed missions

The crew drops one tier if the ship is lost and rebuilt, or if Morale hits 0 during a mission. A Veteran crew transferred whole to a new ship keeps its tier, but this costs 2 Reputation with fleet command.

Task force play. With more than one captain, the group plays as a task force, one ship per player. The Fleet Commander gives the task force one set of orders and names a senior captain, who breaks ties. Each scene is aimed at one ship, and the spotlight rotates. Another ship can **assist** if it is within range and its rating in that department is +1 or better; the rolling ship gets +1. Ships can split up to take separate scenes in the same mission.

Bridge play (one ship). One player is the captain; the others are department heads of their choice (First officer, Helm, Tactical, Science, Engineering, Medical, Operations). Players who would rather not take a post pick up a role card each mission, as on away teams.

- **The captain sets the course.** The captain picks the approach to each scene and keeps the command style, Resolve and Renown.
- **Department heads own their department.** When a roll uses your department, you make it and you choose how. You get +1 (the post bonus) in place of the command bonus, 2 Resolve per mission, and one post ability per mission: Helm (an evasive maneuver cancels one hit), Tactical (one shot ignores 2 shield points), Science (ask the Fleet Commander one yes-or-no question about the scene), Engineering (clear one systems box), Medical (recover 1 Morale), Operations (move an away team one extra time in a scene), First officer (give another player your Resolve).
- **Disagreement is allowed.** A department head may advise against an order once per scene. If the captain overrules and the roll fails, the captain marks 1 Stress or 1 Resolve; if the advice is taken and works, the department head earns 1 Renown.
- **Rotating command (optional).** The captain's chair passes clockwise each mission. The ship and the crew quality stay the same.

Joint away teams. Away teams can mix crew from several ships.

- **Who goes.** A captain can beam down in person, or the player picks up a one-mission role card (Security chief, Science officer, Medic, Engineer, Diplomat) and plays that away lead instead.
- **What each ship contributes.** Each ship sends its lead plus up to 4 crew, limited by its transporters and shuttles. A roll uses the department rating and crew quality of the ship whose lead is acting.
- **Who is in charge.** The joint team names one overall leader, the senior officer present.
- **The ships stay in play.** Players whose leads stay aboard handle transport, sensors, cover fire and the fast exit. Away scenes and ship scenes alternate.

Frontier play (small crews). For ships with a crew of 2 to 20, every crew member is a character. Each player makes one, with a role (Pilot, Mechanic, Medic, Muscle, Face, Captain) and three skills: +2 in one department and +1 in two others. A roll is 2d6 + the ship's department rating + the acting character's skill, with the +4 cap. Crew quality is not used. Each character has 3 Resolve per mission and earns Renown like a captain.

Armada play (a fleet that cannot replace losses). The captains share three fleet resources, each starting at 10 boxes:

- **Fuel.** Each Transit costs 1 per ship. At 0, ships can only move with the fleet's tankers.
- **Food.** Each mission costs 1 per 3 ships. At 0, mark 1 Morale on every ship per mission.
- **Survivors.** The civilians and crew the fleet protects, in thousands. A lost ship costs boxes equal to its size (S 1, M 2, L 3, XL 4). At 0, the campaign is lost.

New ships cannot be bought. Repairs cost Fuel instead of FC (1 Fuel per 3 Hull boxes or 1 systems box). Missions win back resources instead of credits.

Mission requirements. Every mission lists what it needs:

- **Required systems** (for example: long-range sensors, transporters, sickbay). A missing one makes every scene that uses it roll with disadvantage; a missing critical one makes the mission impossible until the ship is refit.
- **Helpful facilities** (a survey lab, diplomatic suites, a captain's yacht). Each one the ship has gives advantage on the matching scene.
- **Crew minimum.** Some missions need a crew count, such as an evacuation that needs room for 2,000 people.

Clocks. Big scenes run on clocks: a circle drawn with 4, 6 or 8 segments. Most scenes need only one roll; use clocks when a scene is a race.

- The Fleet Commander names two clocks, a goal and a danger. On the ship: *Restore the reactor core (6)* against *Containment fails (4)*. Off the ship: *Find the survivors (6)* against *The storm closes in (6)*.

- Success fills 2 segments of the goal (3 on Success, plus). Success at a cost fills 1 goal and 1 danger. Fail forward fills 2 danger.
- Whichever clock fills first ends the scene. The Fleet Commander can spend 1 Threat to tick a danger clock at any time.
- Clocks work the same way for an away team on a planet, a damage-control crisis below decks, or a chase through an asteroid field.

Scene types. The Fleet Commander frames each scene; the captain picks which department acts. A scene succeeds on one success, or needs 2–3 successes before 3 failures for big moments.

SCENE	DEPARTMENT ROLLED	WHAT THE SHIP'S DESIGN CHANGES
Navigation hazard	Helm	Speed, FTL rating, deflector
Survey or anomaly	Science	Labs, cartography, astrometrics, sensor rating
First contact or negotiation	Diplomacy or Command	Diplomatic suites, the lounge, Explorer role
Medical emergency	Medical	Sickbay size, ICU, isolation ward, medical hologram
Engineering crisis	Engineering	Power margin, damage control, Jefferies tube coverage
Away team	Operations or Tactical	Transporter rooms, shuttles, security
Standoff or chase	Tactical or Helm	Weapons, shields; may turn into a Skirmish
Long haul	Command	Supplies, Morale, endurance, holodecks and recreation

Away teams. Each personnel transporter moves 6 people per scene; each shuttle moves 4 and can reach places transporters cannot. If the captain leads the away team, the command bonus applies to the away team's rolls instead of the ship's, and the first officer runs the ship at +0.

Supplies and Morale. Each Transit and each long scene costs 1 Supply. At 0 Supplies, mark 1 Morale per scene. Mark a Morale box to push a failed crew roll. At 0 Morale, the crew demands to return to base.

Turning a scene into a fight. Any Standoff that fails can become a Skirmish on the table, using the same record sheet. Damage taken carries back into the mission.

CAMPAIGN RULES

A campaign links missions with a budget, a fleet and a reputation. The captain and the ship's crew both improve over a campaign, but in different ways.

Fleet Credits (FC). A ship's price is its hull plus what is fitted:

ITEM	COST
Hull	1 FC per 10,000 t of mass (the Explorer is about 520 FC)
Beam weapon (each beam weapon or beam)	10 FC
Torpedo launcher	15 FC
Shield level	20 FC
Shuttlebay level	15 FC
Facility	10 FC (gym, brig) to 40 FC (holodecks, battle bridge, a survey lab)

Power level. Before ships are built, the Fleet Commander sets a power level, the way a DM sets a starting level. It is each captain's build budget, and Drydock tracks it live (Build rules, at the start of stage 1). Unspent credits become the ship's repair reserve. A **free build** has no limit; the app still shows what the ship would cost.

LEVEL	BUDGET	TYPICAL SHIPS	WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE CAMPAIGN
Patrol	500 FC	Scouts, escorts, couriers	New captains. Every facility is a hard choice; missions are local and small.
Line	800 FC	Cruisers, science ships	The everyday fleet. Room for two or three specialist facilities. The default.
Capital	1,100 FC	Heavy cruisers, carriers	Experienced captains. Raise target numbers or stakes.
Flagship	1,500 FC	Explorers, flagships	Very capable ships. Use for short, high-stakes arcs.
Legend	2,500 FC	Prototypes, one-offs	Showcase games and one-shots. Missions should test choices, not budgets.
Custom	Fleet Commander's choice	Anything	Themed campaigns, such as 600 FC for a fleet rebuilt in a hurry after Halcyon Gate.

For reference, the app's templates cost about 470 FC (escort), 610 FC (cruiser), 620 FC (science vessel), 890 FC (carrier) and 1,300 FC (explorer). Mixed levels are allowed: one Flagship and two Patrol ships make a natural task force.

Between missions:

- **Pay.** Missions pay 50 to 300 FC and 1 to 3 Reputation, more for optional objectives.
- **Repairs.** 5 FC per Hull box and 20 FC per systems box. Unrepaired damage stays on the sheet.
- **Refit.** Change the design in Drydock and pay the price difference plus 25% yard fees. Reprint the record sheet.
- **Fleet.** Buy more ships and send them on separate missions. Decommissioning refunds 40% of the price.
- **Growth.** The captain earns Renown and Command traits. The crew rises in quality as missions are completed. A captain who transfers to a new ship keeps their Renown and traits; the new crew starts Green.
- **Reputation** (0–10) unlocks things: 3 opens the next era of technology, 5 opens new roles (Escort, Carrier), 8 opens prototype facilities in an earlier era.

BACKGROUND OPS: CAMPAIGNS IN HISTORY'S SHADOW

Space epics follow a handful of famous ships. Every big event in a setting also involved hundreds of ships nobody wrote songs about. Background Ops campaigns are played by those ships.

Rules of the shadow, for the Fleet Commander:

- **History is the weather.** Write 4–6 big events for your setting before the first session. They happen whatever the captains do. The captains cannot stop the battle at the gate, but they can be the ship that brings its survivors home.
- **The heroes stay offstage.** The famous ships and admirals appear as messages, orders, rumors and names in reports.
- **The aftermath is the adventure.** Ask what each event left behind: refugees, wreckage, a gap in the patrol line, a treaty that needs enforcing, a secret someone wants buried.
- **Small wins add up.** A campaign may never change history, but it changes the captains' corner of space.
- **Divergence is the table's choice.** A group that wants to change history can agree to play it that way.

KIND OF EVENT	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	CAMPAIGN SEEDS
A surprise attack	A colony or station is hit without warning	Relief convoys; hunting the attacker's scouts; rebuilding defenses with untested ships
A long war	Two powers grind against each other along a border	Convoy escort; holding a line; raids behind the lines; rear guards
A great battle	The famous fleet wins, or loses, far away	Salvage and survivor recovery; quarantining what the enemy left; a fleet rebuilding fast
A lost ship	A famous ship vanishes	Search ships; following its last trail; families who want answers
A treaty	A border is redrawn	Patrolling a demilitarized zone; colonists who refuse to leave; friends on the wrong side
A collapse	The jump network, a government or a corporation fails	Scarce fuel; colonies cut off; whether the old flag still means anything
A disaster	A dying star, a plague, a station falling from orbit	A shrinking evacuation; refugees, pirates and hard choices
First contact	Someone new arrives	Escorting the delegation; a misunderstanding at the edge; who gets to talk first

Using the table. Each event gives a three-to-five mission arc: the first mission puts the captains on the scene, the middle ones deal with the aftermath, and the last resolves something the history books never mentioned.

Sample arc: Search for the Meridian (a lost ship).

1. **Into the Shoals.** Requires shields, sensors. Helpful: a survey lab. Scenes: navigate the plasma storms (Helm 10), find the last drive trail (Science 9), a damaged smuggler that may know something (Diplomacy 8, or Tactical 9 to take it).
2. **The smuggler's colony.** Requires transporters or small craft. Helpful: detention cells, diplomatic suites. A colony that hides the smugglers; pressing for answers or earning trust.
3. **Nothing left to find.** One last sweep with readings no one can explain (Science 10). The captains file the report that declares the ship lost. Reward: 250 FC, 2 Reputation.

MISSIONS

Roll three dice to build a mission in a minute: one for the job, one for the place, one for the twist. The Fleet Commander's table in Drydock (Launch → Second Watch → Run a mission) does this on screen and rolls each scene.

D6	MISSION	PLACE	TWIST
1	Survey an uncharted system	Gas giant with unstable moons	An old distress call is still repeating
2	Deliver medical supplies	Colony under quarantine	The cargo is not what the manifest says
3	Negotiate a treaty	Neutral station between two powers	One delegate is an impostor
4	Rescue a disabled ship	Ion storm or nebula	The survivors do not want rescuing
5	Investigate an anomaly	Edge of a subspace rift	Time runs differently inside
6	Show the flag on a border patrol	Contested asteroid field	A rival ship is shadowing you

Complications (d6, on a natural 2 or when the Fleet Commander needs one): 1 a system fails (roll on the critical table), 2 a crew section is hurt or cut off, 3 a storm or sensor blackout, 4 a third party arrives, 5 supplies spoil (lose 2), 6 orders change mid-mission.

SAMPLE MISSION: SHAKEDOWN CRUISE

- **Requires:** FTL drive, sublight engines, sensors. **Helpful:** damage control center.
- **Scenes:** first FTL jump (Helm 8), a coolant leak (Engineering 8, three successes before three failures), a test firing at a target drone (Tactical 7).
- **Reward:** 80 FC, 1 Reputation.

SAMPLE MISSION: THE SILENT COLONY

- **Requires:** transporters, sickbay, long-range sensors. **Helpful:** isolation ward, a survey lab, a shuttle.
- **Scenes:** a colony that stopped answering (Science 8), beaming down through a storm (Operations 10, or a shuttle at 8), a plague with no known cure (Medical 10), a sealed vault under the colony (Engineering or Science 9).
- **Reward:** 200 FC, 2 Reputation, +1 if no away team member is lost.

SAMPLE MISSION: BORDER INCIDENT

- **Requires:** shields, weapons. **Helpful:** diplomatic suites, battle bridge.
- **Scenes:** an unknown ship refuses hails (Diplomacy 9), a standoff at a disputed moon (Command 9; failure becomes a Skirmish), recovering survivors from a wreck (Operations 8).
- **Reward:** 150 FC, 2 Reputation; +2 if no shots are fired.

SETTING DOCTRINES AND OPEN QUESTIONS

Ships use the same rules with their doctrine swapped in: armor belts add Hull boxes equal to their level and reduce every hit by 1 per 3 levels instead of using shields; point defense removes 1 torpedo or missile hit per 2 levels each round; jump drives cross a map edge in one Transit but cost 2 Supplies; sublight-only ships cannot take Transit scenes; spin rings and hydroponics add 1 Morale and 2 Supplies.

Open questions for playtesting:

- Do three-band results and Momentum keep scenes moving, or should Momentum be capped lower?
- Which ship traits come up most, and which never do?
- Do L and XL ships turn too slowly on a 3 × 3 ft table?
- Is 9 shields per facing on the Explorer too tough against a single escort?
- Do department ratings of +4 leave crew quality and command style with nothing to add?